INVESTIGATION & EXPLORATION SYSTEM

Active: Day 3+ **Structure:** Each day divided into time periods — player chooses how to spend each one
Core Loop: Work for money → Explore for information → Manage stats through the night

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DAILY TIME STRUCTURE

Period	Time	Slots	What's Available
Morning	6am–12pm	2 slots	Work jobs only — cash earning window
Noon	12pm–3pm	1 slot	Transition period — free movement, shops open, NPCs accessible
Afternoon	3pm–6pm	2 slots	Exploration, investigation, NPC conversations
Evening	6pm–10pm	1 slot	Limited movement — inn, church, swamp path, Hattie's kitchen
Night	10pm–6am	—	Danger phase — not a player choice unless forced or deliberate

> *Each slot = one meaningful action. Marcus cannot do everything in one day. Choices matter. Day ends when all evening slot is spent or player rests. Night phase triggers automatically.*

MORNING — WORK SYSTEM

> *Two work slots available each morning. Each job pays cash and has a secondary effect. Job board refreshes daily. Some jobs are recurring, some appear once.*

RECURRING JOBS

Job	Location	Pay	Secondary Effect	Notes
Split firewood	Behind inn	$1.50	HEALTH +5	Available every day until HATTIE_DEAD
Sweep & mop	Inn common room	$1.00	AWARENESS +3 — overhears morning conversation	Guest dialogue changes daily
Haul feed	Calhoun's store	$2.00	COMPOSURE check — Calhoun may make a comment	CALHOUN_PROXIMITY active during job
Stack lumber	Mill yard	$2.50	HEALTH +5, MILL_AREA_KNOWN deepens	Foreman drops hints about swamp if rapport built
Deliver groceries	Various homes	$1.00 per stop	AWARENESS +5, town geography expands	Marcus sees inside homes — environmental storytelling
Tend horses	Stable behind feed store	$1.50	INSTINCT +3 — animals respond to Marcus differently as days pass	Horses grow nervous near full moon

ONE-TIME JOBS

Job	Appears	Pay	Secondary Effect
Repair church fence	Day 3	$1.50	CADE_MET — introduces Reverend Cade
Clear brush on north road	Day 4	$3.00	Marcus gets close to the car site — NORTH_ROAD_FAMILIAR set
Help widow Marsh move furniture	Day 5	$2.00	MARSH_MET — elderly widow who remembers the last time something came out of those woods
Paint the mill office	Day 6	$2.50	Foreman talks — mentions strange sounds from north woods at night
Dig drainage ditch near swamp edge	Day 7	$3.00	Marcus gets close to Marie's territory — SWAMP_GEOGRAPHY_KNOWN set
Fix Pruitt's office window	Day 8	$1.50	Pruitt visible at desk — PRUITT_OFFICE_SEEN — notice map of north woods on wall

MONEY — What It's For

Expense	Cost	Notes
Inn room (daily)	$2.00	Waived if FIRST_NIGHT_PAID, then Marcus pays own way
Meals at inn	$0.50	Reduces HUNGER slightly — human food takes edge off
General store supplies	Varies	Bandages restore HEALTH, certain herbs reduce HUNGER
Information (some NPCs won't talk for free)	$1–5	Some secrets cost money to unlock
Marie's remedies	Variable	Barter or trust — she doesn't take cash

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EXPLORATION — INVESTIGATION SYSTEM

> *Afternoon slots are the investigation window. Marcus can visit locations, talk to NPCs, examine environments, and follow threads. Each location has a pool of discoverable information. Some requires multiple visits. Some requires specific flags to unlock.*

INVESTIGATION LOCATIONS

THE MAIN ROAD & STOREFRONTS

Secrets Available: Town social dynamics, who talks to who, Calhoun's influence, strangers passing through **Method:** Ambient conversation, observation

Discovery	How	Flag Required	Info Gained
Calhoun controls the town council	Talk to two different storefront owners	None	CALHOUN_POWER_KNOWN
The last stranger who came through disappeared	Widow Marsh mentions it unprompted after MARSH_MET	MARSH_MET	PREVIOUS_VICTIM_THREAD opened
Pruitt's grandfather helped survey the north land	General store owner, casual mention	PRUITT_REL not hostile	PRUITT_LAND_HISTORY set
Someone has been buying large quantities of rope and chain	General store owner, if asked about recent purchases	$2 bribe	CHAIN_PURCHASE_FLAG — someone is preparing for something

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CALHOUN'S FEED STORE

Secrets Available: Town history, land ownership, Calhoun's agenda **Method:** Work proximity, eavesdropping, direct conversation

Discovery	How	Flag Required	Info Gained
Calhoun owns the land bordering the north woods	Ledger visible during work job	CALHOUN_PROXIMITY	CALHOUN_NORTH_LAND set
A man came through two years ago — Calhoun ran him off	Overheard conversation between Calhoun and associate	Day 5+	PREVIOUS_VICTIM_CALHOUN — Calhoun has done this before
Calhoun knows more about the woods than he admits	His reaction when north woods mentioned in passing	Day 4+	CALHOUN_KNOWS_WOODS — he flinches. Just once.
The chain purchase was Calhoun's order	Cross-reference with CHAIN_PURCHASE_FLAG	Both flags	CALHOUN_PREPARING — for what?

SHERIFF'S OFFICE

Secrets Available: Town law, incident history, Pruitt's family connection to the land **Method:** Direct conversation with Pruitt, observation, PRUITT_OFFICE_SEEN

Discovery	How	Flag Required	Info Gained
Incident reports from two years ago — missing persons	Office visit, ask Pruitt about town history carefully	PRUITT_REL CORDIAL or WATCHED	INCIDENT_REPORT_2YRS — someone went missing. Case closed without resolution.
Map of north woods on Pruitt's wall — areas marked	PRUITT_OFFICE_SEEN from window job	PRUITT_OFFICE_SEEN	NORTH_WOODS_MAP_PARTIAL — certain areas circled, no explanation
Pruitt's grandfather's journal in the desk drawer	Only accessible if PRUITT_REL CORDIAL + Day 6+	PRUITT_REL: CORDIAL	PRUITT_JOURNAL_FOUND — grandfather describes driving natives off the land. Describes what they said would happen if the boundary markers were removed. They were removed.
Pruitt knows about the pack	His eyes when Marcus mentions the north woods at night	Day 5+	PRUITT_KNOWS_PACK — he won't say it. But he knows.

WROUGHTWOOD CHURCH

Secrets Available: Town spiritual history, Cade's breakdown, what lives under the town's faith **Method:** Cade conversations, church records, the building itself

Discovery	How	Flag Required	Info Gained
Church built on a site the natives considered cursed	Old church record, accessible in back room	CADE_MET	CHURCH_SITE_HISTORY — th congregation knew. Built here anywa
Cade saw something two years ago	Cade conversation, E2	CADE_MET + 2 visits	CADE_SAW_SOMETHING
The previous victim was a traveling preacher	Cade's confession, unlocked after CADE_SAW_SOMETHING	CADE_SAW_SOMETHING	PREVIOUS_VICTIM_PREACHE — he was changed. Cade watched it happen. Didn't tell anyone.
Someone has been leaving offerings at the church foundation	Environmental discovery — northeast corner of building	Day 5+	FOUNDATION_OFFERINGS — recent, deliberate. Not Christian offerings. Someone else is still practicing something here.

THE MILL & MILL ROAD

Secrets Available: Pack movement paths, swamp access, worker testimony **Method:** Work jobs, conversation with foreman and workers

Discovery	How	Flag Required	Info Gained
Strange sounds from north woods — regular, not animals	Foreman conversation, Day 4+	MILL_AREA_KNOWN	PACK_SOUNDS_NORTH
A mill worker went missing three weeks ago — officially a drowning	Two mill workers confirm different stories	Day 5+	MILL_WORKER_MISSING — the drowning story doesn't match the location
Path through the swamp connects south end to north woods	Geography revealed during swamp drainage job	SWAMP_GEOGRAPHY_KNOWN	SWAMP_NORTH_CONNECTION — Marie's swamp connects to the pack's territory
Tracks found near mill road at dawn	Morning job near mill — Marcus's INSTINCT reads them	INSTINCT > 15	PACK_TRAIL_FOUND — the pack has been this close to town

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THE NORTH ROAD

Secrets Available: Attack site, pack territory edges, the car, and eventually — the shack **Method:** Direct exploration — each visit unlocks more, higher risk at night **Risk:** Pack presence increases as moon phase advances

Discovery	Visit	Flag Required	Info Gained
Attack site — ground disturbed, two sets of tracks	Visit 1	None	ATTACK_SITE_FOUND — tracks confirm two people, one set changes mid-trail
Boundary markers — several destroyed	Visit 1	None	MARKERS_DESTROYED — the ones intact in the field are exceptions. Most have been pulled up.
Claw marks on trees escalate northward	Visit 2	ATTACK_SITE_FOUND	PACK_TERRITORY_MAPPED — the pack's range is larger than the tree line suggests
A deliberate trail — something has been maintained	Visit 3	PACK_TERRITORY_MAPPED	MAINTAINED_TRAIL — not animal. Not random. Someone uses this path regularly.
Smoke in the deep north woods	Visit 4, daytime only	MAINTAINED_TRAIL	SMOKE_IN_NORTH_WOODS — small fire, consistent, not the pack
THE SHACK	Visit 5+ or directed by Marie	SMOKE_IN_NORTH_WOODS OR MARIE_TOLD_SHACK	SHACK_FOUND

THE SHACK — THE OLD NATIVE MAN

> *This discovery has two paths: find it through persistent investigation of the north woods, or get Marie to tell you. Marie's path is faster but costs TRUST_MARIE capital to unlock.*

FINDING IT THROUGH INVESTIGATION

By Visit 5 of the north road Marcus has been following a maintained trail for half a mile into the woods. The smoke is real. The path is deliberate. Something has been here for a long time and does not want to be found.

The shack appears between two ancient oaks so overgrown with moss and vine that from twenty feet away it looks like a natural formation. It is small. One room. The fire outside is banked low, managed. Nearby — tools, carefully kept. Food stores. Signs of a long, intentional habitation.

A man is sitting outside.

He is very old. His face is a landscape of age — deep-lined, weathered past the point where ethnicity is the first thing you see. Native — his features, his bearing, the particular way he sits that belongs to someone who has been in this land so long the land has stopped noticing him.

He is looking at Marcus.

He does not appear surprised.

GETTING MARIE TO TELL YOU

> *Requires TRUST_MARIE 6+ AND specific conversation path*

During a visit to Marie, Marcus can push deeper about the north woods — what lives there, what knows the land. Marie will deflect the first time. The second time she goes quiet for a long time.

"There is someone," she says finally. *"In the north wood. Old. Older than this town, older than what happened to those people."* She looks at the fire. *"He been watching. Waiting for someone who could do something about it."*

She looks at Marcus.

"He won't come to you. You have to go to him."

"How do I find him?"

"Follow the smoke," she says. *"And don't go armed. He'll know."*

MARIE_TOLD_SHACK set — Marcus gets SHACK_FOUND without needing all five north road visits.

THE OLD MAN — FIRST MEETING

His name, if he gives it, is **Takoda.**

He does not speak immediately. He studies Marcus the way Marie studied him — through rather than at. But where Marie's gaze is diagnostic, Takoda's is something else. Sorrowful, maybe. Tired in the way of someone who has been waiting a very long time for something that has finally arrived and is smaller than he hoped.

He speaks in careful, accented English — not broken, deliberate. Words chosen one at a time.

"I wondered what it would look like," he says. *"When it came back."*

He gestures at the space beside his fire without ceremony.

Marcus sits.

WHAT TAKODA KNOWS

> *Takoda is the game's deepest lore source. He does not give everything at once. Information unlocks across multiple visits, each requiring Marcus to return.*

Visit	Information	Flag Set
1	The land was a place of transformation — not cursed, sacred. A threshold between states. His people tended it for generations.	TAKODA_MET, LAND_SACRED_LORE_1
2	The settlers removed the boundary markers. That removal didn't create the transformation — it removed the *control* of it.	LAND_SACRED_LORE_2
3	The pack is not new. Something has been in these woods for over a century — since the markers came down. It infects, it grows, it waits.	PACK_ORIGIN_KNOWN
4	The alpha is not what Marcus thinks. It is the oldest infected — the first one after the markers fell. It has been here since before Wroughtwood had a name.	ALPHA_TRUE_NATURE
5	Curtis was chosen. Not random. The alpha selects. It looks for people who are already breaking — already carrying something that makes them useful.	CURTIS_WAS_CHOSEN — the gut punch begins here
6	The boundary markers can be restored. It won't remove the pack — but it will contain them. Returning the threshold to what it was. Takoda has been gathering what he needs for decades. He cannot do it alone.	RESTORATION_POSSIBLE

TAKODA & MARIE

If Marcus mentions Marie to Takoda — his expression shifts. Something between respect and an old grief.

"She is still here," he says. Not a question.

"Yes."

He is quiet for a long time.

"She has been here longer than I have," he says finally. *"Longer than my people were here. Whatever she is — she is tied to this land in ways I do not fully understand."* A pause. *"She frightens me. That is not easy to admit."*

TAKODA_KNOWS_MARIE set — opens a new conversation path with Marie where Marcus can tell her Takoda is still alive. Her reaction is the most unguarded she will ever be.

MOON PHASE SYSTEM

> *The moon cycle runs independently of the day counter. Each phase lasts 2–3 in-game days.*

Phase	HUNGER Growth	RAGE Growth	Notes
New Moon	+3 per night	+2 per night	Easiest nights. Wolf is quiet. Marcus sleeps.
Waxing Crescent	+5 per night	+3 per night	Slight restlessness. Dreams start.
First Quarter	+7 per night	+5 per night	Marcus wakes during the night. INSTINCT sharpens.
Waxing Gibbous	+10 per night	+7 per night	Difficult sleep. Wolf abilities accessible more easily.
Full Moon	**+20 per night**	**+15 per night**	**Transformation crisis — see below**
Waning Gibbous	+12 per night	+8 per night	Aftermath. Marcus may not remember the full moon.
Last Quarter	+7 per night	+5 per night	Settling. Human choices feel more available.
Waning Crescent	+4 per night	+3 per night	Near-quiet. Best window for humanity recovery.

FULL MOON — TRANSFORMATION CRISIS

> *The full moon is the hardest night in the cycle. HUMANITY determines whether Marcus holds.*

HUMANITY 70+: Marcus feels it — the pull, the heat, the wolf pacing behind his eyes. He can manage it. Barely. He stays in his room or Marie's cabin. He grips the bedframe. He holds on until dawn. RAGE maxes at 85 and stops. He wakes exhausted but himself. *"You held,"* Marie says, if she's present. She doesn't say she's surprised. She doesn't have to.*

HUMANITY 40–69: The night is a negotiation. Marcus makes it to around 2am before the choice is forced.

[PLAYER CHOICE — FULL MOON NIGHT]

- **Fight it — stay inside:** d20 roll + (HUMANITY/10) vs 15. Success: holds until dawn, RAGE → 20 at sunrise. Fail: partial transformation — Marcus gets outside before going under. Blackout. Morning consequences.
- **Let it happen — go into the woods deliberately:** Controlled blackout. Marcus chooses the north woods. Less collateral damage. RAGE → 5 at sunrise, HUNGER → 5. But PACK_ENCOUNTER — the pack finds him in the woods. What happens next depends on what flags are set.

HUMANITY below 40: No choice offered. Screen goes dark at midnight. *You don't remember deciding to leave.* Full blackout event. Morning consequences scale with how low HUMANITY is.

PACK ENCOUNTER — Full Moon Night in the Woods

> *Triggered by deliberate or accidental blackout into the north woods during full moon.*

Marcus comes back to himself in the woods. Not alone.

The pack is around him — not attacking. Watching. They recognized what he is and came to find him. They are waiting to see what he does.

IF CURTIS_WATCH_FOUND: One of the figures at the edge of the tree-shadow is familiar in outline. Taller than Marcus remembers. Differently built. But the way it stands — the slight lean, the angle of the head — is a thing Marcus has known since he was nineteen years old.

He can't see the face. It's too dark. The moon is full and blinding and the figure is backlit and just far enough away.

CURTIS_SHADOW_SIGHTING set — the closest Marcus has come. He doesn't know it's Curtis yet. But something in him does.

MARCUS'S GROWING ABILITIES

> *As days pass and INSTINCT accumulates, Marcus discovers new capabilities. These are available as human abilities — they do not cost HUMANITY or RAGE.*

Ability	Unlock Condition	Description
Heightened Senses	Day 3, automatic	Marcus can smell emotion — fear, deception, aggression. Passive. Affects dialogue options.
Night Vision	Day 4, INSTINCT > 10	Full visibility in low-light exploration. No lantern needed.
Enhanced Strength	Day 5, HEALTH > 70	Carry heavy objects, break weak barriers. Opens new exploration paths.
Predator's Stillness	Day 5, INSTINCT > 15	Marcus can become functionally invisible when still in shadow. Enables eavesdropping scenes.
Wound Recovery	Day 6, automatic	Minor wounds heal overnight. HEALTH above 50 restores +10 each morning.
Pack Sense	Unlocked via Marie night combat	Anticipate movement before it happens — combat and exploration.
Scent Trail	Day 7, INSTINCT > 20	Follow a specific scent through an area. Unlocks hidden paths in north woods.
Fear Presence	RAGE 30–60 range	Marcus's bearing causes NPCs to step back. Opens intimidation dialogue. Does not cost stats — but witnesses register it.

COMBAT PROGRESSION — Human Fighting Ability

> *Marcus was already capable before the infection. The wolf sharpens what was already there.*

Stage	Condition	Combat Change
Stage 1 — Baseline	Game start	d6 damage, standard defense
Stage 2 — Instinct	INSTINCT > 10	+2 Attack Mod, can read opponent's tells — one free dodge per combat
Stage 3 — Strength	Day 5, HEALTH > 70	d8 damage base, can disarm opponents on 18+ roll
Stage 4 — Predator	PACK_SENSE_UNLOCKED	d10 damage, counter-attack on successful dodge, Fear Presence usable in combat
Stage 5 — Controlled Wolf	HUMANITY > 60 + Stage 4	Lupine abilities available without RAGE cost — the wolf is a tool, not a takeover

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SECRETS MAP — Discovery Tracker

> *Internal tracking of what Marcus knows. Certain endings and conversations only unlock when enough secrets are discovered.*

Thread	Secrets Available	Secrets Needed to Advance
Pack Origin	4	2 to find Takoda, 4 to understand full scope
Alpha Identity	3	All 3 required for final confrontation options
Curtis Truth	5	3 unlocks first suspicion, 5 unlocks full reveal
Harlan / Dominion	4	2 opens CONTAINED thread, 4 completes it
Marie's History	6	Unlocks across trust visits — never fully explained
Takoda's Knowledge	6	Sequential — each requires previous
Pruitt's Legacy	3	2 needed for Pruitt to become a true ally
Calhoun's Agenda	4	3 needed to understand what he's preparing for

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SCENE NOTES

- **The foundation offerings at the church** connect to Takoda without naming him. Someone has been making offerings on land his people considered important. Marcus can mention this to Takoda — his expression tells the whole story.
- **CALHOUN_PREPARING** — the chain and rope purchase becomes clear eventually. Calhoun knows what the full moon does. He's been preparing containment for years. Not out of compassion — out of control. His solution to the pack problem is chains and silence, not resolution.
- **Takoda saying Marie frightens him** is the most revealing thing anyone says about her in the whole game. This man has lived alone in the woods for decades watching a werewolf pack. Marie frightens him.
- **CURTIS_WAS_CHOSEN** landing at Takoda visit 5 means Marcus has been building toward this truth for days. By the time it arrives he has enough context to understand what it means — and to start asking the question he hasn't let himself ask yet.
- **Scent Trail ability** in the north woods is how Marcus eventually finds the path the alpha uses. That path leads somewhere. Takoda will tell him where if he asks the right questions.

FLAGS SET / MODIFIED — Investigation System

Flag	Source
PREVIOUS_VICTIM_THREAD	Widow Marsh
PRUITT_LAND_HISTORY	General store
CHAIN_PURCHASE_FLAG	General store bribe
CALHOUN_NORTH_LAND	Feed store ledger
CALHOUN_KNOWS_WOODS	Feed store observation
CALHOUN_PREPARING	Cross-reference chain + land
INCIDENT_REPORT_2YRS	Pruitt's office
PRUITT_JOURNAL_FOUND	Pruitt's desk
PRUITT_KNOWS_PACK	Observation
CHURCH_SITE_HISTORY	Church records
PREVIOUS_VICTIM_PREACHER	Cade confession
FOUNDATION_OFFERINGS	Church exterior
PACK_SOUNDS_NORTH	Mill foreman
MILL_WORKER_MISSING	Mill workers
SWAMP_NORTH_CONNECTION	Swamp drainage job
PACK_TRAIL_FOUND	Morning job near mill
SMOKE_IN_NORTH_WOODS	North road visit 4
SHACK_FOUND	North road visit 5 or Marie
TAKODA_MET	Shack visit 1
CURTIS_WAS_CHOSEN	Takoda visit 5
RESTORATION_POSSIBLE	Takoda visit 6
TAKODA_KNOWS_MARIE	Marcus mentions Marie to Takoda
CURTIS_SHADOW_SIGHTING	Full moon pack encounter